

Zafira slid the last cardboard box onto the kitchen counter, the tape peeling at the edges. The apartment smelled of fresh paint and the faint ghost of someone else's life. She ran a hand through her long dark hair and surveyed the bare walls, the single armchair by the window, the empty shelves. The silence was thick, but it was hers.

Her phone buzzed on the counter. Daniel's name lit the screen. She let it ring out, watching the vibration walk the box across the laminate. When it stopped, she picked it up and typed a quick reply: "Settling in. All good." Then she put the phone face down, poured a glass of water, and stood by the window, watching the city lights flicker on.

A small notebook lay on the sill, open to a blank page. She picked up a pen, hesitated, then wrote: "What do I actually want?" The question stared back at her. She capped the pen and set it down.

The doorbell rang. She frowned—no one knew she was here yet. She crossed to the intercom and pressed the talk button. "Yes?"

A voice, warm and lilting, crackled through the speaker. "Hi! I'm Reva from the poetry café downstairs. I brought you a welcome gift—a little thing. Can I come up?"

Zafira's thumb hovered over the button. A stranger. A neighbor. A woman with a voice like honey and the audacity to show up unannounced. She pressed the unlock.

"Sure," she said, and the door buzzed.

She ran a hand through her hair again, smoothed her blouse, and told herself this was nothing—just a neighbor being friendly. But her pulse had picked up, and she caught herself wondering what Reva looked like.

The stairwell light flickered as footsteps approached—light, quick, purposeful. Zafira opened the door before the knock landed.

Reva stood there, a small potted plant cradled in one arm, a paper bag in the other. She wore a saffron scarf over a flowing teal skirt, and her dark eyes crinkled with a smile that seemed to have been waiting all day.

“You're taller than I expected from your voice,” Reva said, stepping inside without hesitation. She set the plant on the counter next to the boxes and pulled out a small jar from the bag. “Honey from my mother's village. For your tea. Or your toast. Or your existential crises.”

Zafira crossed her arms, a half-smile tugging at her mouth. “That's a lot of uses for one jar.”

“I'm a poet. We make everything versatile.” Reva glanced around the bare apartment, her gaze lingering on the notebook by the window. “You've got that fresh-start smell. Paint and possibility.”

“Or just paint.”

“Possibility is cheaper, but paint works too.” Reva turned, meeting her eyes directly. “I'm not usually this forward. But something told me you needed a neighbor who doesn't ask questions.”

Zafira's throat tightened. She uncrossed her arms, then crossed them again. “I don't even know what to do with that.”

“You don't have to do anything with it. It's just honey and a plant.” Reva's smile softened. “But if you ever want to talk—about nothing, or everything—I'm downstairs. Every evening, except Tuesdays.”

“Why not Tuesdays?”

“I have a poetry workshop. I'm trying to unlearn the word 'lonely'.” Reva laughed, light and self-aware. “Anyway. Welcome home, Zafira.”

She was at the door before Zafira could form a response, her skirt swishing against the frame. The door clicked shut, leaving the scent of saffron and the small green plant on the counter.

Zafira picked up the jar of honey, held it to the light, and read the label: handwritten, in Bengali script she couldn't decipher. She set it down and walked to the window, watching the street below until a figure in teal emerged, crossed the road, and disappeared into the café's warm glow.

The notebook still lay open on the sill. She picked up the pen and wrote beneath her earlier question: “Maybe I want to find out.”

Tuesday arrived with a nervous flutter in Zafira's chest she refused to name. She spent the morning cleaning the apartment, then stopped herself mid-wipe—what was she doing? It was a poetry workshop, not a date.

Still, she found herself downstairs at seven, the café warm with the smell of coffee and old paper. Reva was at a corner table, surrounded by a small circle of people, a notebook open in her lap. She looked up as Zafira entered, and her face lit up—that same crinkle-eyed smile.

“You came.” Reva's voice carried a soft surprise, like she hadn't quite believed it.

Zafira shrugged, sliding into a chair at the edge of the circle. “You said you'd teach me the words.”

Reva's smile widened. She gestured to the others. “This is the Tuesday tribe. We read, we share, we bleed on paper.” She tapped her notebook. “Tonight's theme is 'beginnings.’”

Zafira's pen hovered over a blank page. Beginnings. She thought of divorce papers, of the empty apartment, of the jar of honey on her counter. She wrote one line: “I'm learning that the first step is always the loudest.”

When it was her turn to read, her voice shook. But Reva nodded, her eyes fixed on Zafira, and something in that gaze steadied her.

After the circle dissolved, they walked out together into the cool night. Reva's scarf fluttered in the breeze.

“You have a voice, you know,” Reva said, quiet. “It just needed a room to speak in.”

Zafira stopped, looking at her—the way the streetlight caught the curve of her jaw, the way she tucked a strand of hair behind her ear. The words came before she could stop them.

“I'm into women, Reva. I think I have been for a while. I just didn't have the words until now.”

Reva's breath caught. She stepped closer, close enough for Zafira to smell the faint jasmine on her collar. “Then let me teach you the rest.”

Zafira's hand reached out, brushing Reva's fingers—tentative, electric. She didn't pull away.

Reva's voice was barely a whisper, her eyes searching Zafira's. "Do you want to walk with me?"

She tucked a strand of hair behind her ear. "I'd like that."

They fell into step, the street stretching ahead under a wash of amber light. Zafira's hands found her pockets, then left them, then found them again.

"You're nervous," Reva observed, a smile in her voice.

"I'm out of practice," Zafira admitted. "With walking. With... this."

Reva's shoulder brushed hers. "This isn't a test. Just two people taking a walk."

"And if I mess it up?"

"Then you mess it up. I'll still be here tomorrow."

Zafira stopped at the corner where the café light pooled onto the sidewalk. She turned, and the words came out rougher than she intended. "I want to kiss you."

Reva's breath hitched. She stepped in, close enough that their shadows merged. "Then do it."

Zafira leaned down, her hand cupping Reva's jaw—gentle, deliberate. Their lips met, soft at first, then deeper, tasting of coffee and honey. When they pulled apart, Reva's eyes were bright, her fingers still curled in Zafira's blouse.

“That,” Reva whispered, “was a very good beginning.”

Zafira laughed, a rusty sound she hardly recognized. “Wait till I learn the next word.”

Reva’s smile turned mischievous. “You might need more than one lesson.”

Reva's fingers lingered on Zafira's collar, tracing the seam. “Lesson one: you don't apologize for wanting something.”

Zafira's jaw tightened. “I wasn't going to.”

“You were thinking it.” Reva's thumb brushed Zafira's collarbone, featherlight. “I can hear the apology in your silence.”

A car passed, headlights sweeping over them, and the moment sharpened. Zafira caught Reva's wrist, not hard, just holding. “You're very confident for someone who just got kissed by a woman who hasn't done this in a decade.”

“A decade?” Reva's eyebrows lifted. “That's a long drought.”

“Marriage tends to do that.”

Reva laughed, soft and warm. “Then we have a lot of ground to cover. Good thing I'm patient.” She tugged her wrist free, laced her fingers through Zafira's, and started walking again, pulling Zafira gently along.

“Where are we going?” Zafira asked, her stride catching up.

“Somewhere with better light. The park's got these old lamps — they make everything look like a poem.”

Zafira's chest tightened, but she didn't pull away. “You're going to make me recite something, aren't you?”

“Only if you want to.” Reva glanced back, a curl falling across her cheek. “Or I could read to you. I know one about a woman who builds walls out of silence.”

“That sounds like me.”

“Maybe.” Reva squeezed her hand. “But walls come down brick by brick, and I've got time.”

They walked in quiet rhythm, the city humming around them. Zafira watched the way Reva's skirt swayed, the confidence in her step, and felt something crack open — just a hairline, but enough.

“Reva,” she said, stopping them under a streetlamp. “What if I'm not good at this? At being with a woman, I mean.”

Reva turned, eyes soft. “You kissed me like you'd been waiting your whole life. I'd say you're doing fine.”

“That was instinct.”

“Instinct is the best teacher.” Reva rose on her toes, brushing her lips against Zafira's cheek. “Lesson two: stop second-guessing. Now come on, the lamps aren't going to wait.”

She pulled Zafira forward, and Zafira let herself be led, heart hammering against the quiet certainty that this — this was the beginning of something she'd never dared to name.

“So what's this poem about?” Zafira asked, her voice steadier now.

Reva smiled, looking ahead. “It's about a woman who thought she was done with love, until a barista with too many scarves showed her otherwise.”

The park lamps hummed overhead, casting pale halos on the gravel path. Reva stopped beneath one, pulling a folded paper from her skirt pocket. “This one's called ‘The Wall Builder.’ I wrote it last monsoon.”

Zafira leaned against the lamp post, arms crossed. “You wrote that about me before you knew me?”

“I wrote it about every woman who's ever been afraid of her own wanting.” Reva unfolded the paper, the edges worn soft. “That includes me.”

The words came low, a rhythm Zafira hadn't heard before — something about bricks laid from the inside, mortar made of withheld breath. Reva's voice cracked on the last line, but she kept going, ending on a whisper: “The wall stands, but I hear her knocking from within.”

Silence settled between them. A jogger passed, shoes crunching on gravel.

Zafira uncrossed her arms. “You wrote that for yourself.”

Reva looked down, folding the paper with deliberate care. “And for the woman who might one day knock back.” She tucked it away, meeting Zafira's eyes. “You're not the only one rebuilding, Zafira.”

Zafira stepped closer, close enough to smell the cardamom on Reva's breath. "What's your wall made of?"

"My family's expectations. The wedding they're already planning in Dhaka, to some cousin's son I've never met." Reva's laugh was dry, hollow. "They think my poetry is a hobby. They think my life here is a phase."

"Is it?"

Reva's hand found Zafira's, thumb tracing the knuckles. "This doesn't feel like a phase. It feels like the first real thing I've written in years."

Zafira's breath caught. She didn't pull away.

"I'm not good at waiting," Reva added, voice dropping. "And I've been waiting for you to ask me what I want."

"What do you want?"

Reva rose on her toes, lips brushing Zafira's ear. "I want to stop knocking."

Reva's lips lingered, warm against Zafira's ear. Zafira's hands found Reva's waist, fingers gripping the thin cotton of her skirt. The words came before she could stop them. "Then stop knocking. Open the door."

Reva pulled back, eyes searching Zafira's face. A slow smile spread across her lips. "That's the first thing you've said that sounds like you're not afraid."

“I'm terrified,” Zafira admitted. “But I'm more terrified of you walking away.”

Reva laughed, soft and bright. “I'm not going anywhere. I've been waiting for you to say that since the first time you looked at me like I was a poem you couldn't translate.”

Zafira shook her head, a dry chuckle escaping. “You're going to use that line on me forever, aren't you?”

“Forever's a long time. I'm counting on it.”

The park lamp hummed. A breeze carried the scent of damp grass. Zafira's thumb traced the curve of Reva's hip. “Come upstairs. I'll make you tea. The good kind, not the café's.”

Reva's eyebrows rose. “That's an invitation?”

“It's a door opening.”

Reva took Zafira's hand, lacing their fingers. “Then let's go before you close it.”

They walked out of the park, past the lamp's halo, into the darker street. Zafira's apartment building rose ahead, its windows dark except for one — hers, lit like a beacon.

At the door, Zafira fumbled with the keys, her fingers clumsy. Reva leaned against the frame, watching. “Nervous?”

“No. Just haven't had company in a while.”

The lock clicked. Zafira pushed the door open, stepping aside. Reva walked in, her eyes sweeping the small living room — the plant on the windowsill, the notebook on the coffee table, the stack of books.

“It's cozy,” Reva said, turning to face her. “I like it.”

Zafira closed the door behind them. The click echoed in the quiet. She moved past Reva, heading for the kitchen. “I'll put the kettle on.”

Reva caught her wrist, gentle but firm. “Wait.”

Zafira stopped, heart hammering.

Reva's dark eyes held hers. “I came up here for tea. But if you want more than that, you'll have to say it.”

Zafira swallowed. “I want more than tea.”

Reva stepped closer, close enough to feel her breath. “Then say it clearly.”

Zafira's throat tightened. The words felt huge in her mouth, but she forced them out. “I want you. Not just tea. I want to touch you, kiss you, see what this is.”

Reva's smile softened, something tender flickering behind her eyes. “That wasn't so hard, was it?”

“It was the hardest thing I've said in years.”

Reva closed the gap, her hands sliding up Zafira's arms to rest on her shoulders. "Good. Because I want you too. I've wanted you since you read that line in the workshop."

Zafira let out a shaky breath. "You're going to have to be patient with me. I'm not... I've never done this before."

"With a woman?"

"With anyone. Not like this. Not with feeling."

Reva's fingers brushed Zafira's jaw, tilting her face up. "Then let me show you. Slowly. At your pace."

Zafira leaned into the touch, her eyes closing. "Okay."

Reva kissed her, soft and searching, a question Zafira answered by pressing closer. Her hands found Reva's waist, pulling her in. The kiss deepened, tongues meeting, and Zafira felt something crack open in her chest — fear, want, all tangled together.

Reva pulled back just enough to whisper, "You're shaking."

"I know."

"Is that good?"

Zafira laughed, a broken sound. "It's everything."

Reva took her hand and led her toward the couch. "Then let's take this slow. Show me what you want."

Zafira sat, pulling Reva down beside her. "I want to kiss you until I forget my own name."

Reva's eyes sparkled. "That's a start." She leaned in, lips brushing Zafira's ear. "But I want to hear you say my name first."

Zafira's breath caught. "Reva."

"Again."

"Reva."

Reva kissed her neck, slow and deliberate. "Good girl."

Zafira's hands tightened on Reva's hips. The word sent heat through her. "Don't stop."

Reva pulled back, a wicked grin on her lips. "Oh, I'm just getting started."

Zafira's heart raced. "Then what are you waiting for?"

Reva's fingers traced the buttons of Zafira's blouse. "Permission."

Zafira reached up, covering Reva's hand with her own. "You have it."

Reva undid the first button. Then the second. Her lips followed the path, leaving a trail of heat on Zafira's skin.

Zafira's head fell back, a soft gasp escaping. "Fuck."

Reva laughed against her collarbone. "We'll get to that."

Zafira's hands slid into Reva's hair, pulling her closer. "Then hurry up."

Reva's eyes met hers, dark and playful. "Patience, love. I've been waiting for this."

Zafira pulled Reva into a kiss, hard and demanding. "So have I."

Reva's mouth found the hollow of Zafira's throat, teeth grazing just enough to make her gasp. "Demanding," she murmured against the skin. "I like that."

Zafira's nails bit into Reva's shoulders. "Don't tease."

"I'm not." Reva lifted her head, dark eyes serious now. "I want to hear exactly what you want. Say it."

The words stuck in Zafira's throat. "I... I don't know how to say it."

"Then show me." Reva took Zafira's hand and guided it to the hem of her own skirt. "Touch me the way you've been thinking about."

Zafira's fingers brushed the fabric, trembling. "I'm scared I'll do it wrong."

Reva's palm covered hers, pressing it flat against her thigh. "Wrong doesn't exist tonight. Only honest." She leaned in, lips close to Zafira's ear. "You've been honest with me since the workshop. Don't stop now."

Zafira's hand slid upward, slow, over the curve of Reva's hip. Reva's breath hitched. That sound—raw and unguarded—sent a pulse through Zafira's whole body.

"There," Reva whispered. "That's it."

Zafira pushed the skirt higher, fingers finding the heat of Reva's skin. Reva's head fell back, a soft moan escaping. Zafira watched her, transfixed.

"God, you're beautiful like this."

Reva's eyes fluttered open. "You're doing it. You're really doing it."

"I want more."

Reva caught Zafira's wrist, stilling her. "Then take it. I'm yours."

Zafira's mouth crashed into hers, hungry and desperate. Reva met her equally, hands fisting in Zafira's shirt. They fell back against the couch, a tangle of limbs and breath and want.

"I've got you," Reva gasped between kisses. "Don't hold back."

Zafira's answer was her hands, gripping Reva's hips and pulling her flush against her. Reva moaned, grinding down, and Zafira lost herself entirely in the feel of it.

"More," Reva breathed. "Please."

Zafira's grip tightened on Reva's hips, pulling her down harder, feeling the slick heat of her through the thin fabric. Reva's head fell back, a guttural sound tearing from her throat.

"Yes," she gasped, "just like that."

Zafira's other hand slid up, under Reva's blouse, feeling the damp skin, the tremor running through her. She leaned in, mouth finding Reva's breast through the fabric, teeth scraping the nipple. Reva cried out, arching into her.

"I want to hear you," Zafira growled, voice rough. "I want to hear what you like."

Reva's eyes were wild, lips parted. "You," she panted. "Just you. Everything you do."

Zafira's fingers found the waistband of Reva's skirt, tugging it down. Reva helped, kicking it off, then straddled Zafira again, bare thighs trembling. Zafira's hand slipped between them, finding her wet, hot, ready.

"Fuck," Zafira breathed, the word a revelation.

Reva let out a broken laugh. "There she is."

Zafira's fingers slid inside, and Reva's laugh became a moan, her hips rolling forward, riding Zafira's hand. Zafira watched her, transfixed—the way her head tilted, the way her fingers dug into Zafira's shoulders, the way her mouth fell open on a silent cry.

"More," Reva begged. "Please."

Zafira added a second finger, curling them, and Reva shattered above her, a long, shuddering cry. Zafira held her through it, feeling the pulse of her climax, the way her body clenched and released.

When Reva collapsed against her, breathing hard, Zafira pressed a kiss to her damp temple. "You okay?"

Reva nodded, face buried in Zafira's neck. "More than okay." Her voice was muffled, thick. "I didn't expect... that."

"What?" Zafira's hand stroked her back, slow.

Reva lifted her head, eyes shining. "You. Taking charge. It's..." She laughed, soft and disbelieving. "Hot."

Zafira felt a flush of pride. "Yeah?"

"Yeah." Reva kissed her, slow and sweet, tasting of salt and want. "I want to see more of that."

The knock cut through the haze like a blade. Reva's body went rigid against Zafira's, her eyes snapping wide with panic. "Oh God. That's Nishat." Her voice came out as a squeak. "She'll kill me. She'll—"

Zafira's hand pressed flat against Reva's mouth, silencing her. "Bathroom. Now." She pointed, and Reva scrambled off the couch, snatching her skirt from the floor, nearly tripping over her own feet as she disappeared behind the bathroom door.

Zafira stood, smoothing her blouse with deliberate calm. She ran a hand through her hair, tucked a stray strand behind her ear. The coffee table—two mugs, one of them half-drunk, Reva's scarf draped over the armrest. She grabbed the scarf and shoved it behind a cushion, then crossed to the door.

Second knock, harder. “Reva? You in there?” Nishat's voice, sharp with concern.

Zafira opened the door, blocking the threshold with her body. “Hey. She's not here.” Her voice came out steady, a little surprised, like the question was odd. “She left about twenty minutes ago. Said something about a bookshop.”

Nishat's eyebrows drew together. “She said she'd be home by nine. It's past ten.” Her gaze flicked past Zafira's shoulder, scanning the room behind her. “Her phone's off too.”

“Probably a dead battery.” Zafira leaned against the doorframe, crossing her arms. “You know how she forgets to charge it.”

Nishat's eyes narrowed, studying Zafira's face. “You sure? She was supposed to bring me a recipe from the café.”

“She didn't mention it.” Zafira shrugged, feeling the lie settle in her gut like a stone. “But she was in a rush. Maybe she forgot.”

Nishat let out a slow breath, shaking her head. “That girl. I swear, she's going to give me a heart attack.” She stepped back, already pulling out her phone. “If she shows up, tell her to call me.”

“Will do.” Zafira closed the door, leaning against it until the footsteps faded down the stairs. She exhaled, long and slow.

The bathroom door creaked open. Reva peered out, eyes still wide. “Is she gone?”

“For now.” Zafira ran a hand through her hair again. “But she's not buying the bookshop thing.”

Reva sagged against the doorframe, clutching her scarf to her chest. “What do we do?”

Reva hugged her knees on the bathroom floor, her voice muffled. “I can't go home tonight. She'll drag it out of me.”

Zafira crouched in front of her, fingertips brushing Reva's wrist. “You stay here. She's not coming back tonight.”

“And tomorrow?” Reva looked up, dark eyes shining. “She'll be waiting downstairs like a hawk.”

“Tomorrow I'll go down with you. Face her together.” Zafira's voice carried no hesitation, just a quiet certainty that surprised them both. “She's your cousin, not your keeper.”

Reva let out a trembling laugh. “You poets and your speeches.” But she reached out, lacing her fingers through Zafira's. “You're not just saying that to get me naked again?”

Zafira's lips twitched. “That's a bonus.” She helped Reva to her feet, guiding her to the bedroom. “Sleep here. I'll take the couch.”

“No.” Reva pulled her toward the bed, tugging Zafira down beside her. “Stay. Just... hold me.”

They lay facing each other in the dim light, Reva's breath warm on Zafira's neck. For a long moment, neither spoke. Then Reva whispered, "What if she tells my family?"

Zafira's hand found Reva's cheek. "Then we'll deal with that when it comes." She traced the line of Reva's jaw. "Right now, you're safe. That's what matters."

Reva closed her eyes, pressing her forehead to Zafira's collarbone. Her body loosened, one breath at a time, until sleep pulled her under.

Zafira stayed awake, watching the rise and fall of Reva's back, the curve of her shoulder in the half-light. She didn't know what tomorrow would bring—Nishat's sharp questions, Reva's fear, her own fragile hope. But she knew this: she wasn't letting go.

Her phone buzzed on the nightstand. A text from Nishat: "If Reva's with you, tell her I'm not mad. Just scared. She can call me anytime."

Zafira stared at the words, thumb hovering over the reply box, then set the phone face-down without answering.

When Reva stirred, mumbling something in Bengali, Zafira pulled her closer. The word for "stay" she had learned from Reva's poems, and she whispered it against Reva's hair.

Reva sat cross-legged on the bed, phone in her lap, thumbs pressed together. "I'm calling her. Speaker. You stay right there."

Zafira moved to the edge of the mattress, close enough to be heard but not seen. Reva dialed, held her breath.

Nishat picked up on the second ring. "Reva."

“I’m okay.” Reva’s voice cracked on the second word.

“I know you’re okay. I’ve known since last night.” A long pause, the sound of a door closing.
“Listen to me. I’m not calling to drag you home.”

“Then why’d you come looking?”

“Because I was scared you’d run off the way I did.” Nishat’s voice dropped low. “I’ve had a girlfriend in Dhaka for six years. Ayesha. She’s a doctor. I never told anyone in the family.”

Reva blinked. Zafira felt her own chest tighten.

“You think I watch you like a hawk because I don’t trust you?” Nishat let out a short laugh. “I watch because I know exactly what it costs to hide. I wanted to make sure you didn’t pay it alone.”

Reva’s hand flew to her mouth. “You—Ayesha? All this time?”

“All this time.” Nishat’s voice softened. “So when you’re ready to introduce me to your woman, I’d like to meet her. Not as your cousin the gatekeeper. As someone who’s been where you are.”

Reva looked at Zafira, eyes wet, a smile breaking through. “She’s right here.”

“Good.” A beat of silence. “Then tell her I’m sorry for the interrogation. And that she’s got good taste.”

Reva's laugh came out wet and broken. "She says you've got good taste." She wiped her cheek with the back of her hand, still smiling at the phone.

Zafira's throat tightened. She pressed her palm flat against the mattress, grounding herself. "Tell her... thank you. And that I'd like to meet her properly. Both of them."

Reva relayed it, her voice steadier now. Nishat chuckled on the other end. "Sunday. My place. I'll cook something that isn't hospital cafeteria food."

"Sunday," Reva echoed, looking at Zafira for confirmation. Zafira nodded, a slow warmth spreading through her chest.

"Good." Nishat's tone shifted, softer. "Reva. I'm proud of you. That's all I wanted to say."

Reva's breath hitched. "I love you, didi."

"I know. Now go enjoy your Saturday. And turn your damn phone on." The line clicked dead.

Reva set the phone down, staring at the blank screen. She turned to Zafira, eyes still glistening. "She has a girlfriend. Six years. I never knew."

Zafira reached out, brushing a strand of hair from Reva's face. "You're not alone in this."

Reva leaned into the touch, then let out a shaky laugh. "I need tea. Real tea. Not the instant stuff you hide in your cabinet."

Zafira rose, offering her hand. "I have loose-leaf. Somewhere." She pulled Reva up, and they walked to the kitchen together, the morning light slanting through the window.

As Reva busied herself with the kettle, Zafira leaned against the counter, watching her. The fear she'd carried for months felt lighter, like a coat she'd finally shrugged off.

Reva caught her gaze and smiled. "Stop staring. You'll make me burn the water."

The kettle clicked off, steam curling into the air. Reva poured the water slowly, watching the leaves unfurl in the pot. "She wants us to come Sunday," she said, almost to herself. "To her place. Her and... her girlfriend."

Zafira picked up a spoon, turning it over in her fingers. "That's real. That's actually happening."

"I keep waiting for the other shoe to drop." Reva set the teapot down, hands trembling slightly. "Like Nishat will call back and say it was a joke. Or that my mother somehow heard and is already booking a flight."

"Would she do that?"

"Fly here? She'd try." Reva let out a hollow laugh. "She'd say it's for my health. Then sit in my kitchen and pray loud enough for the neighbors to hear."

Zafira set the spoon down and crossed the small distance between them. She took Reva's hands, stilling them. "We'll deal with that when it comes. Not before."

Reva looked up at her, dark eyes searching. "You really mean that? You're not going to bolt?"

"I'm here," Zafira said simply. "I'm not going anywhere."

Reva let out a breath she'd been holding. She leaned in, pressing her forehead against Zafira's shoulder. "Okay," she whispered. "Okay."

They stood like that for a long moment, the tea cooling untouched. Zafira's hand came up, resting on the back of Reva's head, fingers threading through the dark waves.

"Sunday," Zafira said quietly. "We'll go together. Hold hands on the train if we want."

Reva laughed, wet and warm against her shirt. "You're already planning public affection. Very bold for a woman who barely said two words to me at the café."

"I'm a fast learner."

Reva pulled back, grinning now. "Prove it." She turned to the counter, poured two cups of tea, and handed one to Zafira. "Tell me something you've never told anyone."

Zafira wrapped her hands around the cup, the heat seeping into her palms. She thought for a moment. "I used to practice tying knots," she said. "Rope. In the garage, when Daniel was at work. I'd watch tutorials on my phone and feel like a fraud the whole time."

Reva's smile softened, not mocking. "Why a fraud?"

"Because I was married to a man and thinking about being tied up by a woman." Zafira took a sip of tea, not meeting her eyes. "Or tying one up myself."

Reva set her cup down and stepped closer. She took the cup from Zafira's hands, set it aside, and took both her hands again. "You're not a fraud. You're just late to your own life."

Zafira's breath caught. "That's... a kind way to put it."

"It's the truth." Reva squeezed her fingers. "And Sunday, I want you to hold my hand in front of Nishat. Show her you're not hiding either."

Zafira nodded slowly, a tightness in her chest loosening. "I can do that."

"Good." Reva let go, picking up her tea again. "Because she cooks spicy. You'll need something to hold onto when the chili kicks in."

Zafira laughed, real and surprised. "Noted."

The phone buzzed on the counter, rattling against the ceramic tile. Zafira glanced at the screen—Daniel's name. She let it ring twice before picking up.

"Zafira. You're alive." His voice came through tinny and cautious.

"Barely. What do you need, Daniel?"

"Just checking in. You missed our usual Tuesday call." He paused, and she heard him shuffle papers. "I ran the numbers on the alimony adjustment. You're clear for another six months. I can send the spreadsheet—"

"Don't send the spreadsheet."

Reva raised an eyebrow from across the counter, sipping her tea, pointedly not listening.

Daniel cleared his throat. "Right. Okay. Are you... seeing anyone?"

The question hung in the air, and Zafira felt Reva's gaze slide toward her, warm and steady.

"That's not really your business anymore," Zafira said, and the words came out easier than she expected.

"No, I know. I just—" He exhaled, and for a moment he sounded like the man she'd married, earnest and slightly lost. "I want you to be happy, Zafira. That's all."

"I am."

She said it without thinking, and realized it was true.

There was a long silence on his end. Then, quietly: "Good. That's good. I'll let you go."

"Thanks, Daniel."

"Take care of yourself."

The call ended, and Zafira set the phone down, her hand still resting on it.

Reva set her cup down, voice light. "Ex-husband checking in? Very modern of you."

Zafira turned to face her. "He wanted to know if I was seeing anyone."

“And you said?”

Zafira crossed the kitchen and took Reva's hand, threading their fingers together. “I said I'm happy.” She lifted Reva's knuckles to her lips, brushing a kiss across them. “That's enough for now.”

Reva's smile softened, her eyes bright. “I think I like this version of you.”

“I'm still figuring her out.”

“Good,” Reva said, squeezing her hand. “Take your time. I'm not going anywhere.”

“You know what I want?” Reva asked, setting her cup down with a deliberate click. She rounded the counter, backing Zafira against the fridge, her hips pressing close. “I want you to make me forget my own name.”

Zafira's breath caught, hands finding Reva's waist. “That can be arranged.”

Reva tilted her head, a slow smile curling her lips. “I want to feel you in my bones. I want you to take control and not let go until I'm shaking.” She leaned in, mouth brushing Zafira's ear. “I want you to fuck me like you mean it.”

A sharp knock cut through the air. Zafira froze, glancing toward the door.

“Don't stop,” Reva whispered, nipping her earlobe. “Let her hear. Let her know exactly what I am to you.”

Zafira's hands tightened on Reva's hips, pulling her flush. “You sure?”

“I've never been more sure of anything.” Reva reached for the hem of her own shirt, pulling it over her head. “Now show me what you've been practicing.”

The knock came again, harder. Nishat's voice through the wood: “Reva? I brought your charger. And I need to talk to you—”

Reva's fingers worked Zafira's blouse buttons open. “Ignore her.” Her voice dropped, husky and deliberate. “I want to hear you moan my name, Zafira. I want her to hear it too.”

Zafira's resolve cracked. She lifted Reva onto the kitchen counter, spreading her thighs, pressing between them. Reva's head fell back, a throaty gasp escaping as Zafira's mouth found her neck, her collarbone, the swell of her breast.

“Yes,” Reva breathed, arching into her. “Right there. Don't you dare stop.”

Through the door, Nishat's voice faltered. “Is that—Reva?” A pause, then the muffled shuffle of footsteps retreating down the hall.

Zafira pulled back just enough to whisper against Reva's skin. “She's leaving.”

Reva laughed, low and breathless, tangling fingers in Zafira's hair. “Good. Now take me to the bedroom and show me what a photographer sees when she finally gets the shot she's been chasing.” She pulled Zafira's mouth back to hers, swallowing the moan that followed.

Zafira scooped Reva off the counter, Reva's legs locking around her waist as she carried her down the hall. The bedroom door swung open with a kick, and Reva laughed against her mouth as they tumbled onto the bed, a tangle of limbs and breath.

“That's it,” Reva whispered, pulling back just enough to meet Zafira's eyes, pupils blown wide. “Forget the rest of the world. Just us.”

Zafira's hands roamed Reva's bare torso, tracing the curve of her ribs, the dip of her waist. “I want to hear you.”

“Then make me loud.” Reva arched up, offering her throat. Zafira took the invitation, lips and teeth marking a path down her neck, her chest, until Reva's breath came in sharp, staccato gasps.

“Like this?” Zafira's fingers slipped beneath the waistband of Reva's skirt.

“Faster.” Reva's nails dug into Zafira's shoulders. “Harder.”

Zafira obliged, her rhythm turning ruthless, and Reva's head thrashed against the pillow, a cry ripping free—her body shuddering as Zafira worked her through it, relentless until the last tremor faded.

Reva lay panting, chest heaving, a lazy smile spreading across her flushed face. She reached up, tracing Zafira's jaw. “I could get used to this version of you.”

“I'm still figuring out who that is.” Zafira's voice was rough.

“Then take your time.” Reva pulled her down for a soft kiss. “I'm not going anywhere. Now come here. Let me return the favor.”

Reva's hands found Zafira's hips, tugging her closer, guiding her down onto the mattress. “My turn.” Her voice dropped, low and deliberate. “And I don't plan on being gentle.”

Zafira's breath hitched, a flicker of surprise crossing her face before she settled into a slow grin. "You think you can handle me?"

"I think I can handle whatever you give." Reva's fingers worked the buttons of Zafira's blouse, patient, unhurried. "But I want to see you lose that control for once."

Zafira's hands tangled in Reva's hair, pulling her up for a hard kiss. "Show me."

Reva shifted, straddling Zafira's thighs, pinning her down with surprising strength. She leaned in, lips brushing Zafira's ear. "You've been running this show all night. Let me take the wheel."

Zafira's chest rose and fell, a rare vulnerability flickering in her eyes. "... I don't usually—"

"I know." Reva's mouth trailed down her neck, teeth grazing skin. "That's why I want this. I want to see the part of you that doesn't have to be in charge."

Zafira's head fell back against the pillow, a low moan escaping. "Fuck."

"That's it." Reva's hands slid lower, nails dragging across Zafira's stomach. "Let go. Let me hold you for once."

Zafira's hips bucked instinctively, her fingers gripping the sheets. "Reva..."

"I've got you." Reva's voice was soft but certain, a promise in the dark. "Just feel."

Zafira's body trembled, the fight draining out of her as Reva took over, slow and deliberate. And for the first time in years, she let herself be caught.

Morning light crawled across the ceiling. Zafira's eyes snapped open, her skin still warm from last night, and her stomach clenched. She'd let herself be pinned. Let herself be held. The memory sat wrong, like a stone lodged under her ribs.

Reva stirred beside her, a soft sound escaping her lips, eyes still closed. Zafira moved before her brain caught up — out of bed, pulling the silk scarf from the dresser drawer, the one she'd never worn, the one she'd bought because the knot practice needed something with give.

By the time Reva blinked awake, Zafira was already straddling her, scarf looped around Reva's wrists, cinched tight to the headboard with two clean wraps and a locking hitch.

Reva's eyes widened, then softened. A slow smile. “Well. Good morning to you too.”

Zafira leaned in, mouth brushing Reva's ear. “You think you can take control that easy? I've been practicing longer than you've known what you want.” Her voice came out harder than she meant. Sharper.

Reva's wrists flexed against the scarf. Not testing it. Reading it. Her smile faded by a degree.

“This is nice,” Reva said, voice gentle. “But you're not doing this because you want to.”

“I'm doing exactly what I want.” Zafira's hand slid down Reva's stomach, pressing flat against her hip.

“No.” Reva's gaze held hers, unblinking. “You're doing this because last night scared you. Because I had you, and you didn't know what to do with that.”

Zafira's hand stilled. The knot in her chest pulled tighter.

“Zafira.” Reva's voice dropped, soft as a line of verse. “Tie me up because you want to taste me. Not because you're running.”

Zafira's jaw worked. The scarf was already too tight, the hitches too precise, every loop a wall she'd built overnight. She looked at Reva's wrists, then at Reva's face, and for a long moment she couldn't find the words.

“What if I don't know how to do this any other way?”

Reva's fingers curled, brushing Zafira's wrist where it rested on her hip. “Then we learn it together. But not with me tied up like a punishment for letting you feel something.”

Zafira's breath came out shaky. She reached for the first knot, her fingers hesitating on the silk.

The first knot slipped loose. Then the second. Zafira's fingers moved like they belonged to someone else, slow and deliberate, until the scarf fell away and Reva's wrists were free.

Reva didn't move. Didn't rub the marks. Just watched Zafira's face like she was reading a line that needed another pass.

“You're shaking,” Reva said.

Zafira looked down at her own hands. She was. “Habit.”

“That's not a habit. That's a wall.” Reva sat up slowly, the scarf pooling in her lap. She reached out, palm flat against Zafira's chest, right over the heartbeat. “This is what I want. Not the knots. Not the control. You. Messy. Unsure. Here.”

Zafira's throat tightened. “I don't know how to be that.”

“Then don't know.” Reva's thumb traced a slow circle. “Just stay.”

Zafira exhaled. Something cracked inside her chest, clean as a bone snapping straight. She leaned forward, forehead against Reva's shoulder, and let herself be held.

They stayed like that until the morning light turned gold. Reva's fingers carded through Zafira's hair, slow and steady. No words. No knots.

Finally Reva spoke. “Sunday. Nishat's dinner. You still with me?”

Zafira pulled back just enough to meet her eyes. “I said I'd hold your hand. I meant it.”

Reva's smile came soft, like dawn. “Good. Because I already told her you're coming.”

Zafira's fingers stilled against Reva's shoulder. The words “I already told her” hung in the air like smoke from a candle just blown out. She pulled back, studying Reva's face for any sign of a joke.

“You told her what, exactly?”

Reva shrugged, casual as a cat stretching. “That my girlfriend is coming to dinner. She asked. I didn't lie.”

“Girlfriend.” Zafira tested the word, felt it settle in her chest like a warm stone. “That's what I am?”

“Unless you want a different label.” Reva tilted her head, eyes soft. “Partner. Lover. The woman who makes me forget my own name. I'm flexible.”

Zafira's laugh came out rough, almost a cough. “You're impossible.”

“And you're avoiding the point.” Reva reached up, brushed a strand of hair from Zafira's face. “Sunday. Nishat's apartment. You, me, her girlfriend, and a table full of food I'm probably going to burn. You still in?”

Zafira looked at the scarf on the bed, the loose knot she'd fumbled. Then at Reva's open face, waiting without pressure.

“I'm in,” she said. “But if your cousin gives me the death stare, I'm hiding behind you.”

Reva laughed, bright and sudden. “Deal. But you owe me a poem for that.”

“I don't write poems.”

“You don't know that yet.” Reva slid off the bed, padded toward the bathroom, then paused at the door. “You're full of things you don't know about yourself. I'm looking forward to finding them all.”

Zafira watched her go, the door clicking shut behind her, and pressed a hand to her own chest where Reva's palm had been.

Reva's voice floated from the bathroom, muffled by running water. "You know, I'm not going to tell Nishat about the scarf thing."

Zafira's hand dropped from her chest. "What scarf thing?"

"The one you're probably still holding." The water shut off. "Or the fact that you tied me up and then froze like a deer."

Zafira looked at the silk still pooled in her lap. "I wasn't frozen. I was thinking."

"Thinking about what? Whether to add another knot?"

"Whether you'd still want dinner Sunday after last night." The words came out smaller than she intended.

A beat of silence. Then Reva appeared in the doorway, towel wrapped around her hair, wearing one of Zafira's old button-downs. "Zafira. Look at me."

She did, reluctantly.

"I told my cousin you're my girlfriend. I slept in your bed. I let you tie me up, and then I untied myself and talked you through it." Reva crossed the room, took the scarf from her hands, and tossed it onto the nightstand. "If I was scared off by a little vulnerability, I'd have run the first night you kissed me."

“That was different.”

“No, it wasn't. That was you being brave. Last night was you being brave too. It's the same courage, just a different kind.” Reva sat on the edge of the bed, close enough that their knees touched. “Sunday isn't about the sex. It's about walking into a room where someone might judge us and not caring. That's it.”

Zafira let out a long breath. “And if Nishat's girlfriend makes a comment about me being older?”

“Then I'll recite a poem about age being just a number, and she'll be too embarrassed to say anything else.” Reva grinned. “I have one ready. It's called 'You're Not My Mother, So Stop.’”

Zafira laughed despite herself. “You're ridiculous.”

“I'm practical. There's a difference.” Reva leaned in, pressed a quick kiss to her forehead. “Now, I'm making tea. You're going to sit there and tell me one thing you're looking forward to on Sunday. Just one. No walls.”

Zafira watched her walk toward the kitchen, the shirt hanging loose on her small frame. “Holding your hand,” she said quietly. “In front of someone who knows your family.”

Reva paused at the doorway, glanced back. “See? That wasn't so hard.”

“Don't get used to it.”

“I'm already used to it.” Reva disappeared into the kitchen, and the sound of the kettle clicking on filled the apartment.

Zafira stayed on the bed, bare feet on the floor, and let herself feel the small warmth spreading through her chest — not the heat of lust, but something steadier, like the first sip of tea on a cold morning.

She didn't reach for the scarf.

She didn't need it.

Saturday afternoon found them on the living room floor, a spread of books between them. Reva sat cross-legged, one finger tracing the spine of a worn poetry anthology while Zafira leaned back against the couch, reading glasses perched low on her nose.

“You’re not even looking at the pages,” Reva said, tilting her head.

“I’m looking at you.” Zafira didn’t glance up. “Better view.”

Reva laughed, tossed a cushion at her. It bounced off Zafira’s shoulder and landed in her lap. “Flattery won’t get you out of explaining Bengali verb conjugation.”

“It’s not flattery. It’s observation.” Zafira set the book down, slid her glasses off, folded them into her pocket. “You bite your lip when you’re concentrating. It’s distracting.”

“Maybe I do it on purpose.”

“Then you’re succeeding.”

Reva leaned forward, elbows on her knees, grin slow and deliberate. “Good. Now teach me something useful. Something I can’t find in a book.”

Zafira considered her. “What do you want to know?”

“How to tie a knot that doesn’t come undone when I’m pulling against it.”

Zafira’s breath caught. She reached for the silk scarf draped over the armrest, ran it through her fingers. “That’s not a lesson for the floor.”

“Then where?”

Zafira stood, held out her hand. “Bedroom. And you’ll do what I say.”

Reva took her hand, let herself be pulled up. “And if I don’t?”

“Then I’ll make you.” Zafira’s voice dropped, low and steady. “That’s the other thing I can teach you.”

They walked down the hallway, Reva’s fingers laced through hers, and the door clicked shut behind them.

Reva stood in the middle of the room, arms loose at her sides. “So what’s the first rule?”

“You don’t ask questions.” Zafira stepped close, looped the scarf around Reva’s wrists, once, twice. “You feel the pressure, and you tell me if it’s too tight. That’s all.”

“And if it’s not tight enough?”

Zafira tugged the knot snug, watched Reva’s eyes darken. “Then I’ll fix it.”

She guided Reva to the bed, pressed her down onto her back, wrists above her head. Zafira knelt over her, one knee between Reva’s thighs, and leaned close enough to feel her breath.

“Good,” Zafira murmured. “Now hold still.”

Reva’s chest rose and fell faster. “And if I don’t?”

Zafira smiled, slow and sharp. “Then I’ll remind you who’s in charge.”

Reva arched beneath her, testing the scarf, but the knot held firm. She let out a breath that was half laugh, half moan. "You're good at this."

Zafira's fingers trailed down Reva's arm, featherlight. "Practice."

"Show me another." Reva's voice was steady, but her hips shifted. "Teach me what you know."

Zafira reached for a second scarf on the nightstand, ran it through her hands like a ribbon. She looped it around Reva's ankle, then the other, binding them together with a neat double knot. "This one's about restraint. You can pull, but you won't get far."

Reva pulled. The silk held. She grinned up at Zafira, dark eyes bright. "I like that one."

"Yeah?" Zafira leaned down, mouth brushing Reva's ear. "You like being stuck?"

"I like being yours." Reva's words came out low, a confession she didn't have to make.

Zafira stilled. The heat in her chest flickered — something raw, unnamed. She pulled back just enough to meet Reva's gaze, thumb tracing the knot at her wrist. "That's a dangerous thing to say."

"Why?"

"Because I might believe it." Zafira's voice cracked on the last word, and she looked away, jaw tight.

Reva's bound hands reached up, catching Zafira's chin, gentle but insistent. "Then believe it."

Zafira exhaled, slow. She pressed her forehead to Reva's, letting the words settle somewhere deep. "I'm trying."